October 22, 2026: What’s the Point

“Every game begins with ‘love’.”

— Arthur Ashe (or he should have)

“Ben there, done that.”

— Everyone

I’ve told some of you this story before, so excuse me for repeating myself. But the story came back to me recently when I was trying to tell a friend what it was like when new Town Councilors were elected.



Some people, new to a role—especially new to authority—sit back and are quiet, watchful, and perhaps a bit timid. They try to get an understanding of the work, culture, personalities, and issues, relying on more experienced people on the team until they can develop confidence to contribute and lead. They begin with questions. Other people take on the role confident in their understandings, capacities, and mandates, hammering away on what they perceive those mandates to be. They start with the answers and slowly discover the questions. And then there are the relatively few who take on a title determined to assert their new position, to post “wins,” to assert authority, and to reform and reshape how decisions are made and how power is distributed. And they want an audience while they do it. At least at first, they’ve come to knock down those they perceive to hold influence.

I found myself at times trying to explain in frustration to a new boss: “You know I work for you, right? I’m here to pass you the ball so you can score, and I’m here to run blocking for you. We’re on the same team, so beating me doesn’t advance our goals very well.” We all make this mistake sometimes; it’s not only elected officials. They just happen to land in positions without prior experience and with a desire to make change. Most of the time (but, alas, not all of the time), people learn fairly quickly to work together, to help one another, to learn much more about the questions if they think they already have the answers, and to learn the answers if they have only the questions. It’s discovery in progress, where we all figure out how to make it work… and it usually does. It helps to understand where they are coming from; it helps if they know where we are headed together.

When explaining this to my friend, I recalled and shared the true story of playing tennis with Ben one day a dozen or so years ago. We arrived at the court, and Ben went to one side while I took the other. He would serve an easy stroke to me, and so I would charge the net and smash the ball back at him, or try to spin it, or otherwise score the point. It worked — I had the answers. I was winning — bigly! (I should note here that we are both terrible tennis players, so the description I offer here is far more about my intent than my actual result.) After a bit, Ben picked up the ball and walked calmly to the net

and kindly asked, “I think we are playing different games. What do you think we are playing?”

Well, duh! “Tennis, and I’m crushing it!”

“No. I’m placing the ball so you can hit it back to me; you’re hitting it back so I can’t get it. We’re playing volley, and you suck at it.”

At first, I was a little at a loss, then a wee bit embarrassed, then greatly relieved. It was, after all, boring always waiting for him to walk slowly back to the fence to pick up the ball just to lob it over easy again. Then… the dim, flickering light finally came on. Duh is right! If Ben ever has a gravestone, I won’t be surprised if it has his name and two dates, and an inscription that simply says, “But that’s not the point.” He’d be right again.

Before you can get on the same page, you have to be reading from the same book.

Happy Thinksday